MEANING OF INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

It is not an easy task to give the precise meaning of international relations which when capitalized and reduced to the acronym 'IR', specifies a field of study taught in universities and colleges as a 'subject' or a 'discipline'. The difficulty increases manifold because of the tendency to use the terms 'international relations' and 'international politics' interchangeably. Often it is taken for granted that IR is the study of international politics only. Morgenthau[1] and others viewed the core of international relations to be international politics and the subject matter of international politics to be struggle for power among sovereign nations. Padelford and Lincoln[2] also opine that, when people speak of 'international relations', they are usually thinking of the relationships between states. They further contend that such relationships between states constitute 'international politics' which is the interaction of state policies within the changing patterns of power relationship.

But international relations means more and, as Palmer and Perkins[3] point out, international relations is related to not just politics of international community centring on diplomacy and relations among states and other political units, it means 'the totality of the relations among peoples and groups in the world society'. Therefore, the term 'international relations' is not only broad but means more than the official political relations between governments on behalf of their states. As Hoffman[4] suggested, the discipline of IR "is concerned with the factors and activities which affect the external policies and the power of the basic units into which the world is divided".

Palmer and Perkins[5] observe that IR "encompasses much more than the relations among nation-states and international organizations and groups. It includes a great variety of transitional relationships, at various levels, above and below the level of the nation-state, still the main actor in the international community".

Wright[6] contended that international relations include "relations between many entities of uncertain sovereignties" and that "it is not only the nations which international relations seek to relate. Varied types of groups—nations, states, governments, peoples, regions,